

Aggressive Tactics

There is always a change in the feel of the training room when team time comes around. A greater sense of friendly competitiveness that only happens when RSI's best fighters - each of whom was busy pursuing her own individual success just yesterday - come together to chase victory as a group. Well, three groups, to be precise. Three teams of eight fighters - one from each weight class. As stablemates, these women always have each other's back. But, for the next month or so, they would drive each other like no other time. Secrets would be shared, strategies would be developed, and, most interestingly, intra-stable competition would hit its peak.

But something was different, this time.

It didn't jump out immediately, as my first tour through the training floor revealed mostly what I expected. Britney and Elisha - the leaders of our two original teams - were busy trading good-natured barbs, while Aly - who headed up our most recent addition - worked with Daniela to get the less experienced Krystal Forscutt ready for her upcoming opponent. The other team members all seemed to be engrossed in similar activities as they helped each other prepare.

The first thing that seemed amiss was when I spotted Danni sparring with Emma. What made it odd? Well, being two weight classes lighter, Emma was giving away some size. But, the stranger thing was the way they were going at it. I arrived to find Emma's limbs flying in from all angles as she drove her larger foe across the cage. Danni was put on her heels - guarding and moving furiously to defend herself, while being forced to eat a few shots she couldn't avoid. Despite the heavy blows, she kept her focus and, when she finally found an opening, she dug in deep and fought back hard. The tables were turned instantly, and now it was Emma who reeled under a barrage of heavy blows.

The more I watched them go back and forth, the more convinced I was that something had happened. Though both are generally pretty level-headed, it was clear their tempers had gotten the better of them because they were playing for keeps. I was thinking about putting a stop to it, and I glanced around at the other fighters nearby, wondering why no one else seemed as concerned as I was. Instead, they seemed to be getting into it. Not necessarily choosing sides, but they were definitely entertained by the intense action.

Danni kept pressing forward, and Emma sensed the cage coming. She tried to slide right, but Danni was quick to cut her off.

BOOM, BOOM!

First the left, then the right landed as Danni's fists exploded into Emma's face. Powerful shots that rocked the younger fighter, and drew some groans from the others. Clearly, it was time for Ms. Watson to call for a break and collect herself. After all, this was training, not fight night.

That's not how it went, though. Instead, Em shook off the blows and grabbed at her opponent. It was not an inherently great idea. Danni was larger and stronger, and Em didn't have much hope of controlling her.

But the surprise of the move caught Danni unprepared, and Emma was successful in slowing things down for just a second. Calming the action just when Danni was hitting her stride.

It was a calm that didn't last.

The quicker Emma drew her hands back and shot a jab into the center of Danni's face. Danni's guard came up and Em went low with a straight right to the gut, followed by a solid left hand to the bigger fighter's side. Danni responded with a quick jab and a crushing elbow to the side of Emma's head, drawing a chorus of *oohs* and *woahs* from their audience. Watson came right back with a big right hand that found its mark and a fight-ender of an uppercut that just missed Danni's chin. Danni surged forward to take advantage of the miss, then had to lean back in a panic as Emma spun out a high kick that also missed by the smallest of margins. The evasive maneuver threw Danni off-balance, and she stumbled a few steps before she pulled it together.

The group was totally entranced now, with sporadic clapping and shouts of encouragement filling the room.

Danni turned to face her tiny tormentor with a broad smile. Emma's eyes burned with excitement and intensity, and that patented, mischievous smirk was plastered on her face. Small nods were exchanged. Then the guards went back up and the battle resumed, though it was clearly not the angry confrontation it had first appeared to be.

I shook my head in modest disapproval, but made no move to put a stop to things. I didn't particularly like the idea of them tearing into each other like that, but I also trusted them to know what they were doing. Especially those two. So, I bit my tongue, shook my head again, then walked on because I had an appointment to keep.

I found the rookie trio looking mostly lost in a cage on the opposite side of the room.

With the experienced fighters tied up in team prep, we didn't have a lot of options in the day care department. Putting them in the hands of the few, slightly more experienced fighters who weren't busy didn't seem right, which left me as the only one available who had any hope of getting anything out of them.

As I entered to join them, I heard one of them mumble, "Oh, here we go," and it sounded to me like it had a little wiseass in it.

"Now, now, children," I said. "Don't make me put you in time-out before we even get started."

One of them clicked her tongue in disgust. I looked to figure out which, but they were all wearing the same indignant scowl so I couldn't tell.

"Why does everyone talk to us like we're kids?" Dove asked.

"Coupla reasons," I said. "First, to most of us, you ARE kids."

They responded with the same scowls, showing the same indignance. And I knew reason number two was only going to make it worse, but I didn't care. I had an opportunity here. For the next few weeks, they were mine, and I planned to go straight at them. Though I may not be able to replace the combined breadth of skill and technique of the RSI veterans, I did have things I could teach. Among them, was a proper sense of respect. Respect for their stablemates, respect for the sport and respect for their opponents.

But first, I was going to have to earn a little respect for myself.

"Second," I continued, "you act like kids."

"No, we don't," Dove pouted.

"Yes, you do. We all make light of it, but it's really not that funny. You guys tend to waste a lot of time."

"So, we have a little fun sometimes," Daya said. "What's so wrong with that?"

I took note of the fact that her words were sharp and clear. No playing around with her casual, street-like dialect. I took that as a sign that she was serious. Or, at least, seriously annoyed.

"There's nothing wrong with a little fun, unless it distracts you from what you're after. And don't tell me that's not happening. All three of you looked terrible the other night."

"Hey! That's not fair!" Dove protested. "I won!"

"Yeah, great. You found someone even worse than you are. Meanwhile, your two buddies here got their asses handed to them by people I've never heard of."

None of them had anything to say about that.

"We can be better than that," Liv snapped.

"I agree, but you've been training with some of the best fighters around, and we all saw the results."

"And you think you're the answer? You're not even a fighter."

"You know better than that."

"No, I don't. I've HEARD things, but we've never seen it."

"Who'd did you hear those things from?"

She shrugged.

"The others."

"And their opinions aren't good enough for you?"

A little grin creased her face.

"We want to see it for ourselves."

"I'm not here to give a demonstration."

"You don't think I can give you a challenge?"

"Did you bring a bat with you?"

"No."

"Then no."

The other two were smiling a little now too, and I realized they thought this was some sort of game. They were seeing how far they could push me. Like toddlers testing their boundaries.

"I think I can," Liv said confidently.

I won't lie. There was a part of me that wanted to smack some sense into her, right then and there. But I took a moment to imagine what the subsequent conversation with Danni would be like and decided to try acting like a responsible adult instead.

"I'm not fighting you," I said.

"Why not?"

"Because there's a damn good chance you'll get hurt."

"That sounds like a cop-out."

"Believe what you want. It's not happening."

Liv paused a moment. Trying to think of a new way to goad me. She turned her head - first to Dove and then to Zendaya - and I saw the light go on in her head.

"There are three of us, and only one of you," she said.

Oh, you sweet, innocent child...

"That's a bad idea," I said.

"For you, maybe."

The smiles broadened on all three faces. Thinking they had me.

I thought of Danni again, then brushed the concern aside. There comes a point when being the adult means showing the inexperienced youth who's boss.

"You shouldn't say things like that unless you mean it, Olivia."

She snorted.

"You really think you can take all of us together?"

"I think you should reconsider your plan or you're going to find out."

Though I was hopeful they might still be reasonable about this, I casually slid my right foot back. Setting my stance, just in case.

The worst part about what happened next was that they took the time to think about it. Liv stared at me for a moment, then looked again at Dove and Zendaya. Between the three of them, they silently considered the situation. And then, as a group, they made the wrong decision.

Liv took an aggressive step in my direction and I immediately brought my right foot forward and drove it into her gut. Fair? Maybe not, but neither were the three to one odds. So, if we were going to do this, I wanted to make sure we did it my way.

Caught totally unprepared, the blow doubled Liv over and she dropped to the mat. As my foot came down, I whirled around and drove the back of my right elbow into Daya's face. She'd been fast enough to flinch a bit, so I didn't get the impact I wanted. Enough that she was going to need a second to gather herself, but it wasn't going to put her down.

My movement left me facing Dove, who'd had enough time to get her guard up and set herself. She shot out her jab, rising out of her stance and ruining her balance as she did it. The same damn rookie mistake she made all those months ago. I slipped the punch, grabbed her arm and slung her into Daya, sending them both toppling to the canvas.

Liv was just getting up, so I sent another kick into her belly and knocked her back down.

Dove and Z scrambled back to their feet. I'll give them credit - they learned pretty fast. Without saying a word to each other, they spread apart. Dove to my right and Daya to my left. Making my life harder by giving me two distinct opponents to fight.

Behind me, Liv groaned as she started to roll herself over again, which meant I needed to make a move. Two was never a problem, but handling three at once could be tricky.

I started with the larger of my upright opponents and lunged toward Zendaya while watching Dove out of the corner of my eye. The move surprised the brunette, and she scurried back to stay out of my reach just as her blonde counterpart surged forward. I switched targets - planting my left foot and pivoting into a long, straight left hand that landed in the center of Dove's face. The force of the punch combined with her forward momentum to create a vicious impact that sent her stumbling. I followed - taking a long stride onto my right foot, then whipping my left leg around and pounding a kick into her side. I kept the pressure on as I felt Daya coming up behind me. Jab, cross, left hook then stepped in close and drove the front of my right elbow into her nose. Dove went down hard and I got my feet planted, then kicked straight backward without looking. Daya had been quick to stay on me but she hadn't been careful about her approach, and the kick found her right where I expected her to be. My foot sank deep into her belly and pushed her away. She wobbled unsteadily, and I was all over her. Left, right, left... my fists were flying faster than she could react and everything was landing. I finished the sequence with a right uppercut that exploded under her chin and sent her spilling to the canvas.

I turned around to find Olivia about halfway to her feet.

"Stay down, Liv," I said, but she didn't so I swept her feet out from under her and sent her crashing down on her back. Then I brought my leg up high in front of me and slammed it down - driving my heel into her gut. She let out a loud, *OOOOF!* and made no further attempt to get up.

I stood near the center of the cage and looked around at the three women I was supposed to be teaching. Each was conscious and groaning, but none seemed eager to resume the fight.

Lesson learned? That remained to be seen.

"I'm going to give you guys a few minutes to get yourselves together," I said, "then you can let me know how you want to spend the rest of today's session. My suggestion is that we start over and try a different approach, but it's entirely up to you."

I started toward the cage door, then paused after I undid the latch.

"Just so this wasn't a total waste, here's a lesson for you," I said to them. "Always know what you're up against before you put your mouth off."

I walked out of the cage, turned the corner and discovered everything else in the gym had ground to a halt.

"Get back to work," I said sharply as I crossed the room.

Danni and Emma were still in the cage, and Danni was looking at me with an expression that said maybe I shouldn't have done that.

I walked on to my office without saying anything because I was afraid she might be right.

I didn't know what to think about what had just happened. On the positive side, I was a little bit impressed with the way I'd kept my temper. My tactics may have been aggressive, but they were also deliberate. I

gave those three idiots multiples chances to smarten up but they kept asking for it, so I gave it to them. And, in a way, maybe I had been venting some frustration. Though I hadn't let my anger get away from me, I was definitely sick of this. I had no doubt they could be better than what they were, and I was tired of waiting for them to figure that out. These next few weeks were going to be my shot at getting through to them. If this is what it took, so be it. They were the ones who decided to challenge me. Backing away would have put me in a bad spot right from the start and that simply wasn't going to work for me. So I did what I always do.

Hit someone and see what shakes loose.

Only now, I wasn't sure what I had accomplished. I told myself that maybe this would leave a bigger impression. They were playing a game they thought they couldn't lose, and maybe being beaten despite the odds would help wake them up. After all, it wasn't my fault they didn't know I had punched my way out of far more difficult situations in the past.

Or maybe I was kidding myself. Maybe it would be a disaster of epic proportions, and I had kicked the crap out of three of my own fighters for no reason. Chances were good that I'd go back out there and find them more petulant than ever. That I had done nothing more than unite them in shared hatred for me.

But before I got to any of that, I was going to have to deal with Danni.

I have to admit, I was a little surprised. I expected her to come roaring in and let me have it, but she was cool and contained when she entered my office a few minutes later.

"It would have been nice if you'd told me what you had planned before you went on the warpath," she said as she eased her way into my guest chair.

Her tone was steady, with no noticeable anger in it.

"No plan," I said with a shake of my head. "I didn't know it was going to happen until it happened."

I figured that would be the detail that would set her off. That I had acted so drastically without an endgame in mind. But she didn't make an issue of it.

"I'm not saying they didn't have it coming, but that was kind of a big risk to take," she said.

"It didn't seem like they were going to listen anyway. They were more interested in testing my patience."

"Looks like they found the limit."

"Not really," I said. "I'm not happy it went that way, but that wasn't me losing it."

She gave me a look that said she wasn't buying my story.

I shrugged.

"They were looking for trouble, and I gave it to them. They needed to be put in their place, so to speak."

She nodded steadily but there was something in her expression. A look of apprehension that made me wonder if things in the training room had already started to go south.

"How bad is it?" I asked.

"Hard to say," she shrugged. "Tiz went in to pick them up, but they were still a little shaky when I left."

"Tiz pissed?"

"No. I don't think anybody's pissed. Except maybe those three. And Steph."

I frowned for a second before I understood.

"Because she wanted to be the one to knock them around?"

Danni nodded. I think she was trying to be funny, but it was a valid point. Steph had put up with a lot more nonsense from the rookies than I had.

"That's fair," I mused. "I'm gonna have to make that up to her."

We both smiled, but she still looked a little tense.

"Something's bothering you," I said.

She shrugged, then gave voice to the same concerns that had been bounding around my head.

"I've got no argument with what you did, but I don't know how it's going to play. They may shut you out completely, now."

"Like I said, they weren't going to listen, anyway. I was already being shut out."

She nodded again and we were both quiet for a moment.

"So how do you see this ending?" she asked.

"That's up to them. They've been fucking around long enough. It's time for them to decide if they're in or out."

"And if they're out?"

"Then I'll be disappointed, but this has to stop."

She thought a bit more to see if there was anything else to discuss. Then her eyes came up to mine.

"Alright, I'm with you. What do you want to do next?"

"Go out and settle everybody down and get them back to work. When they're up to it, send the rookies in here."

I could see the concern in her eyes. The little meeting I'd just proposed was bound to get ugly.

"You want me here?"

I started to answer, but a different set of thoughts jumped into my head before I could get the words out.

Here, I had done what might have been the most dramatically stupid thing I possibly could have. I had knocked three of my own fighters flat on the floor. Despite my misgivings, I knew why I'd done it, but how did Danni know? How was it that she understood me so easily and completely?

As I looked at her now, I was once again faced with the realization that something was happening to me.

I pushed the thoughts aside and got back on track.

"No. I did it, I'll own it. Besides, it's not like they're much of a threat."

"I don't think I would say that to them."

"I won't have to. They already know."

With nothing else to say, she got up to set the plan in motion. But she only took a few steps before she paused.

"You've done that before," she said without a hint of doubt.

"More than once," I said, "against much more dangerous people."

She digested that, then a little smile appeared.

"It was pretty awesome to watch."

"I know," I grinned. "Now, let's see what kind of impression it made on the children."